

Temple University Libraries: Blind Date with a Book

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INFO 649

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December 10, 2025

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Abstract

In this proposal, we intend to address the issues of student retention and wellbeing through encouragement of leisure reading. The Charles Library has an existing fiction collection in the atrium on the first floor [see Figure 1]. To further advertise it, we would like to hold a Blind Date with a Book event in the atrium close to Valentines Day. At this program, participants will take a quiz and be matched with a selection of books they might enjoy. They then would get the opportunity to browse these titles and check out any books of interest. Additionally, light refreshments would be offered, along with a DIY bookmark craft, and a Cupid's arrow archery game to win a gift card to a local bookstore. Through this event, we hope to increase library usage among low or non-library users, increase checkouts of the leisure reading collection, and increase awareness of library resources outside of those related to coursework.

Community

The Temple University Libraries is an academic library focused on supporting the academic and creative needs of members of its entire academic community. The libraries offer a plethora of services to aid with the success of everyone's time at Temple University. These services range from access to research materials like books, articles, journals, databases, etc. to special collections materials. The library also offers assistance through subject research guides, and individual meetings with subject specific librarians. The Temple University Press also falls under the purview of the

library and members of the university can interact with The Press by learning about the publishing process. The library also offers programming which consist of events, exhibits and workshops to help university members explore the library's resources and their personal interests (Temple University Libraries, n.d.).

The Temple University Libraries are part of the larger Temple University which is a large public research university located in North Philadelphia and serves around 30,000 full-time and part-time students. The University consists of both undergraduate and graduate degrees with the average cost of undergraduate tuition set at around \$21,000 (DataUSA, 2023). According to DataUSA, the racial demographics break down of enrolled students is the following: "45% White, 15.5% Black or African American, 14.5% Asian, 9.33% Hispanic or Latino, 3.85% Two or More Races, 0.175% American Indian or Alaska Native, and 0.0596% Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islanders" (DataUSA, 2023). The most common degree concentrations at Temple are general psychology, general biological sciences, and marketing (DataUSA, 2023).

The Temple University Libraries acknowledges both the scope and scale of the community it serves through its mission statement, key function, operating principles, and strategic actions. Temple University Libraries lists the following as its mission statement "connecting people and ideas to enhance learning, research, clinical practice, and creativity" (Temple University Libraries, n.d.). The libraries list their key functions as supporting the community by providing the staff, facilities, collections and services to support instruction, study, and scholarship. They also provide instructional and service engagement by providing learning environments to develop key skills like critical thinking and information discovery, provide the tools and materials to extend students

reach in scholarship and research and aid with the spread of ideas through publishing, outreach, and programming (Temple University Libraries, n.d.).

The Temple University Libraries also abides by a certain set of principles that influence how they operate within the university space. These operating principles are stewardship, personalized and proactive services, intellectual rigor, openness, historically informed and future directed library and publishing practices, innovation and experimentation, partnership and collaboration, civic hospitality, diversity and inclusion, accessibility, and accountability. These set of core principles openly lay out the ways in which the university libraries dedicate what they do and who they are to serve their community of users, students, staff and faculty alike (Temple University Libraries, n.d.).

The strategic actions provided by the university library go into further detail about what specifically is done by the department to serve its users. The strategic actions show the ways in which the department is set up to “foster learning, enhance intellectual life, amplify scholarly impact, and extend the reach of the imagination for their diverse local, national, and global communities through concerted action” (Temple University Libraries, n.d., para. 1). The key areas targeted by the strategic actions include: designing a library environment that serves as a jumping off spot for academic enterprise, creating an enriched environment dedicated to student success, developing programs and services to foster intellectual productivity, exploring scholarship opportunities, creating partnership opportunities for innovation, serving as a central space for intellectual and cultural life on campus, and providing a space for archival and collection repositories (Temple University Libraries, n.d.).

In 2017, the Temple University Libraries assessed their diversity and inclusion initiatives and developed a diversity statement committing to serving the full diversity of the Temple University academic community. This commitment to diversity and equity extends to the staff of the university and beyond through the libraries' collections and services. The Temple Libraries acknowledge that the current demographics of the staff do not align with the community they serve and are actively participating in rectifying that (Temple University Libraries, n.d.). This commitment to diversity shows that the libraries are dedicated to strengthening their knowledge of the community which Hildreth describes as necessary to meet a community's particular interests and needs and to ensure that reciprocal relationships are being built (Hildreth, 2021).

While the Temple University Libraries consists of a series of libraries focused on differing subjects and specialties, the library program we've developed will happen at the Charles Library specifically, which is the main campus library. The Charles Library, like all the other libraries located at Temple University follows the same mission statement, has the same key functions, and follows the same set of principles, however as the main campus library it serves as a more general, cross disciplinary library. This means that the users attending the Charles Library are bound to be a bit more diverse. The Charles Library, which opened in 2019, is made up of a variety of spaces dedicated to a diverse cross section of the campus like graduate student and faculty area, the Student Success Center, and the University Press. The library is also made up of a plethora of multi-use spaces and reading areas, a café, the Special Collections Research Center, the Loretta C. Duckworth Scholars Studio which functions as a makerspace, and the Book Bot retrieval system. The diverse offerings of the Charles

Library are especially situated to meet the diversity of needs of the Temple University Community (Temple University Libraries, n.d.).

Target Audience

The target audience for this program are students on main campus who underutilize the library, or do not utilize it at all. The library tracks usage data for a variety of services, and also further divides this data by college. Using printing as an example, from Fall 2018 to Fall 2024, there has been an approximate 10 percent drop in students utilizing printing services (Turner, 2025). This shows that what once was a prominent use of the library has tapered off, undoubtedly impacted by the move to Charles Library in 2019, and the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020 (Turner, 2025). This data has been used to reallocate resources, such as removing redundant computers (Turner, 2025). Because of the change in student needs, the library has an opportunity to reallocate resources to draw students in, and leisure reading is under advertised, but beneficial to student well-being.

Some schools, like the law school, podiatry school, and the health sciences [i.e. Medicine, Pharmacy, Nursing, etc.] have their own libraries, so while they may not be visiting Charles Library, they instead may be using another library that best aligns with their program of study. Due to this, we would also want to prioritize students who are not better served at other library locations. According to the library's swipe access data and patron transaction information for Fall of 2024, students from the College of Science and Technology were the most likely to use the Charles Library, with 79.6% of the total number of students enrolled in the college captured (Turner, 2025). The schools with the highest potential for improvement are the College of Liberal Arts and

the College of Education, as the percentage of library users to total enrolled students for these schools are significantly lower among the colleges without their own dedicated libraries (Turner, 2025). From the data, we can target these two schools specifically, especially in marketing the program.

Statement of Need

We at the Charles Library have recognized a need to increase the number of users accessing our library services. In comparison to the large size of the university and the student body population, the percentage of students who use library resources, collections, and spaces often is statistically lower than we would like. The library is a space uniquely tied to fostering an environment of student success and enhanced learning outside of the classroom as mentioned in the libraries mission statement and key functions and by increasing library usage we hope to increase student success and learning campus wide.

We aim to improve these statistics by increasing foot traffic in the libraries, and increasing the amount of collections that receive regular use by the student body to increase awareness of the full scope of the functions of the library and the ways the students can utilize these resources to aid in their learning and success. We recognize that increasing usage amongst low library users and increasing the usage of resources can be quite a large and lofty goal to accomplish and so we've created the Blind Date with a Book Program to focus our approach and make reaching our goals easier to track.

The rationale between developing the Blind Date with a Book Program to specifically increase the awareness and circulation of our leisure reading section directly correlates to research in the library sector regarding the link between leisure reading amongst university students and an increase in academic success, learning, and wellbeing.

The inclusion of leisure reading collections in academic libraries is not a new phenomenon. Leisure reading collections first began in academic libraries around the 1920s and 1930s and were part of the initial core values set by academic librarians to promote reading generally. These collections became less available in the 1940s and 1950s because of budget constraints due to the war but have increased in popularity again beginning in the 1990s (Fargo, 2018). “More recent studies have shown the benefits of reading for leisure, including a correlation with higher academic achievement (National Endowment for the Arts, 2004), promotion of critical thinking, and improvement of reading comprehension and developing one’s own writing voice (Rathe & Blankenship, 2006; Trott & Elliott, 2007)” (Fargo, 2018, para. 3). Hurst et al. builds on this discussion by mentioning the ways in which leisure reading can help fill in the gaps for colleges and universities concerned with students entering post-secondary education ill-prepared and lacking in the critical skills needed. Student use of the library can be an indicator of their success at university (Hurst et al. 2017).

Literature on the benefits of leisure reading collection in academic libraries also points to the ways in which having regular access to reading materials for more personal purposes as opposed to academic purposes goes beyond making them better students in the classroom but also helps with a student’s general wellbeing and mental

health (Hurst et al. 2017). Temple University conducted a student basic needs survey between Spring 2023 and Summer 2024, and mental health and wellbeing was one of the subjects reported on. “In terms of mental health, 44% of students reported experiencing clinically significant symptoms of anxiety and/or depression and 57% of survey respondents who had previously stopped out (stopped attending college without completing a credential and subsequently re-enrolled) reported they did so because of mental health issues” (Temple University, 2025). 79% of students who responded to the survey who had stepped out of college and then re-enrolled or were thinking of stepping out of college cited basic needs insecurity, which includes stress and mental health as one of the reasons for leaving or wanting to leave Temple University (Temple University, 2025). These statistics directly reflect a larger university issue as reported by Temple University’s Office of Institutional Research and Assessment. Overall retention rates have been on the decline since 2022, more prevalent amongst non-Pennsylvania residents, which dropped from 81% to 79% between 2023 and 2024. Retention declines can be seen in specific communities like the Latino and Native American student body at Temple University (Temple University, 2024). Providing and encouraging leisurely reading in the academic library as shown in the literature is one way to increase student learning and wellbeing, thus moving us closer to executing the Temple Libraries’ mission statement, key functions, and objectives.

To get more students to read and check out the leisure reading collection at Charles Library, we’ve identified the need to get students into the library to even reap the benefits of what leisure reading has to offer them. Bosman, Glover and Prince (2008) discuss the ways in which colleges are often insular communities and academic

libraries are perfectly situated to fill the void of the third space and help students develop a sense of deeper connection and belonging to the institution, further aiding with increasing the rates of retention mentioned above. To do this, however, first academic libraries must very intentionally work on their image. Academic libraries are often thought of as high stress areas reserved for studying (Bosman, Glover & Prince, 2008). With much of university moving to an online model, the library has shifted to meet that online model as well meaning that more investment has been put into online material with less of an in-person focus. Students perceive this as having less reason to visit libraries in person and believe that libraries lack relevance in their lives. A recent OCLC report shows that college students don't think of libraries as their first choice for reading material, 66% look to bookstores as the best place for current reading materials and 9% consider search engines a good fit for their lifestyles (Dewan, 2013). Academic libraries can look to the model used by public libraries to help reinvent their image as places that allow for leisure. This model places programming initiatives front and center to engage community engagement and can help academic libraries blur the line between being a space for research and leisure (Dewan, 2013). By incorporating more active programming like the Blind Date with a Book Program to encourage students to enter the library and explore our non-academic related leisure reading section, we hope to help students reimagine what an academic library does.

Intended Results

Increase in library usage among low/non-user populations

As discussed in the statement of need, frequent library usage has a plethora of benefits for students. Additionally, as discussed in the target audience section, there are several student populations that have lower rates of library usage compared to the total enrolled student body in those colleges. After attending this program, we hope that participants will become frequent library users, which will serve to improve their academic performance, as well as increase retention rates. One semester after the delivery of the program, we would like to see a 5% increase in student swipe access to Charles Library, and a 3% increase in study room reservations.

Increase in checkouts for leisure reading materials

Per the statement of need, leisure reading has a positive effect on student wellbeing and mental health, which in turn improves retention rates. After attending this program, we hope that students will utilize the leisure reading collection, and in turn improve their wellbeing by taking time away from coursework. We would like to see a 5% increase in the number of books checked out from the leisure collection each month following delivery of the program.

Increased awareness of library resources outside of typical academic contexts

With the underuse of library resources as a concern, providing a broader view of what the library has on offer can draw new users into the space. As shown by the printing data presented in the target audience section, there has been a marked decrease in some service areas, which has contributed to less student library usage. After attending this program, we hope that students will be more aware of what the Charles Library offers, as well as think of the library outside of their academic needs. One month after the program is held, we would like to see a 5% increase in tracked

clicks on materials not directly intended for coursework in the online catalog. One semester after the program is delivered, we would like to see a 7% increase in circulation of materials not directly intended for coursework.

Partner Organizations

Co-curricular programming, which is a type of program development used by libraries to proactively complement learning, activities and interests outside of class, has been proven to be a successful model for academic librarians. As author Katy Kelly (2020) states “co-curricular programming can enhance student learning, and libraries can shape their own strategies as they collaborate with other university or community partners” (pp. 331). It is this emphasis on collaborating with other branches of the university to holistically serve student needs that we used when thinking through the campus departments, organizations, and clubs that we’d partner with for the Blind Date with a Book program. We at the Temple Libraries felt like the following organizations were the most aligned with our programming goals.

The Temple University Book Club is a student organization that meets monthly and focuses on recent works of fiction. Including the Temple student book club provides them the platform to showcase their organization to recruit new members and increase interest in leisurely reading. We also intentionally want to collaborate with this organization to help with the selection of fiction that we’d like to display and promote to the students to increase awareness of our collection and garner more foot traffic. As a student organization, this club has a better understanding of the types of works that

students might gravitate towards, and their input is vital into our understanding of the popularity of our collection.

We chose to reach out to the English Department of Temple University as a partner for the program because of their unique position of both their understanding of literature but also because of their deep knowledge of the ways that literature shapes critical skills like writing, critical thinking and analysis, perspective, and attention to detail (Temple University, 2025). We hope to tap into their key understanding of the way reading literature affects skills for success that will play out throughout students' times at the university and beyond.

Temple's Student Health Services has been invited to table because of both our commitment to improving student wellbeing and the general theme of the event itself. Student Health Services provides services aimed at students staying well and healthy. These services range from general health to sexual health, and mental health (Temple University, 2025). As a library program scheduled around Valentine's Day and focusing on general themes like dating and romance, we thought it fit to invite the student health organization to make their services visible and allow them the space to promote the resources they have in place regarding sexual health and health in general. We believe that the Student Health Services department should have a high contact presence with all students and are always willing to provide them with that platform.

Our inclusion of Temple University's Planned Parenthood follows much of the same strain of thought used for including Student Health Services. Planned Parenthood is an organization focused on providing education and access to reproductive health services to help students better understand human sexuality and their rights (Planned

Parenthood Generation Temple University, n.d.). Temple University Planned Parenthood will be tabling within the library space to provide access to general information and resources.

Stella's Café, which is located on the first floor of the Charles Library by both the atrium where the program will be held and the New Books and Leisure Reading section, will partner with the event to provide beverage options for purchase (Temple University, 2025). The cafe has been asked to create a custom drink exclusively for this library event to help show the full extent of what the Charles Library has to offer students outside of academic materials and study spaces. Because of the floor plan, the cafe will also be utilized as a spill over space for students gathering on the first floor. We've requested that Stella Cafe stay open for a few additional hours for the library program.

Program Goals and Objectives

Worksheet for Determining Goals, Objectives, Outcomes, Activities, and Resources

Goal/Outcome	Objectives	Activities that Foster the Goal/Outcome	Resources/Inputs Needed
1. Increase in library usage among low/non-user populations	Students who use the library frequently perform better in their coursework.	Students use library spaces and collections.	Library collections (existing resource)
	Improved student performance increases retention rates.	Library programming	Library spaces/seating (existing resource)
	Academic libraries serve		

	as third spaces, providing a gathering place for the campus community.		
2. Increase in checkouts for leisure reading materials	Students who read for leisure are more successful academically and have overall better wellbeing.	Students peruse the leisure book section and check out materials.	Leisure reading collection (existing resource)
	Improved student wellbeing increases retention rates.	Library programming	Book displays (existing resource)
			1 staff member to change the display monthly (funding = staffing budget)
3. Students will increase their knowledge of breadth of library collections	Students will be aware of the full scope of library resources, allowing them to utilize the library more effectively.	Student usage of collections offered by library not tied to classwork	2 of library staff and 10 hours per month (funding=staffing budget)
		Students explore/familiarize themselves with library website to explore less visited collection and resources	Meeting room (existing resource)
		Library programming	IT assistance with highlight collections on library website (1 staff, 1 hour per month) (funding = staffing budget)

Project Activities

Event activities

- Cupids arrow raffle game to win gift card to Uncle Bobbie's
- Arts and crafts bookmarks using old magazines, finished with laminator.
 - Full materials list:
 - Old magazines
 - Strips of cardstock
 - Glue sticks
 - Scissors
 - Laminator
- Buzzfeed-style quiz for getting matched with new book
- Snacks
- Partner organizations tabling
- Stacks open for exploration and checking out of books
- Specialty drinks from the cafe to coincide with event theme
 - Strawberry latte (coffee or matcha & hibiscus lemonade/tea)

Lead up/preparation:

- Contact partner organizations, schedule tabling
- Supervise creation of quiz by Book Club.
- Purchase gift card, snacks and refreshments, prizes, supplies for Cupid's arrow game.
- Prepare craft materials
- Facilities: Set up/take down (how many tables/chairs, additional trash receptacles)

- Decor: purchase/print/etc.
- Marketing (flyers, social media, newsletter, email, school media outlets (radio, print, etc.), other campus outlets, etc.)
- Library will need to staff the book matching station, craft table, game, possibly schedule additional support for circulation
- Coordinate with café
- Prepare book selection, organize into categories based on quiz results.

Schedule

- **September 8, 2025**-reserve space (special services)
- **September 8-October 6, 2025**: design marketing materials, begin event planning. (personnel, special services, support services)
- **October 13-October 17, 2025**: conduct outreach to partner organizations, create quiz in cooperation with book club, facilities, and cafe (personnel, special services).
- **November 12, 2025**: announce event, begin marketing (special services, personnel, support services)
- **January 2026**: purchase/create decor, purchase food, and drink. (materials)
- **January 8, 2026**: finalize library event staffing (personnel)
- **January 20-23, 2026**: pull reading selections for event. (materials)
- **February 12, 2026**: Day of event
 - Pre 3:00 pm: final tasks, involved staff meet to review game plan.
(materials, personnel)

- 3:00 pm-4:00 pm: General set up, decor. (materials, special services)
 - 4:00 pm-4:45 pm: partner organization arrival and set up (support services, personnel)
 - 4:30-5:00 pm: allotted time for catering set up (materials)
 - 5:00-7:00 pm: hold event
 - 7:00 pm-8:00 pm: break down and clean up (personnel, support services).
- **February 17-March 10, 2026:** evaluation period

Method of Evaluation

OUTCOMES-BASED EVALUATION PLANNING TABLE

Goals/Outcomes	Inputs	Activities	Outputs	Outcome Targets	Outcome Indicators
Student population will learn about the Blind Date with a Book Program	Library Staff and Temple Marketing team (funding= staffing budget & budget for marketing needs like the copy center)	Promoting the program	Flyers, newsletter, library website, digital signage, student radio show appearance	80 students attend the library program	Door count of students entering the library to attend the program the day of
Program preparation	Tables, snacks, crafting supplies for crafting table, fiction & nonfiction in leisure reading section, book displays, decorations, supplies for cupid's arrow game, gift card for	Purchase snacks, decorations, and craft supplies. Set up a tabling section. Set up book displays. Set up games and activities.	Snacks, crafts, cupid's arrow game, book pairing quiz, decoration, book	Snacks, crafts, cupid's arrow game, book pairing quiz, decoration, book displays, raffle	Successful purchase of supplies and set up for the program.

	raffle. Creating book pairing quiz. (funding = \$3000)		displays, raffle		
1. Students will increase their knowledge of breadth of library collections	2 of library staff and 10 hours per month (funding=staffing budget) - Meeting room (existing resource) - IT assistance with highlight collections on library website (1 staff, 1 hour per month) (funding = staffing budget)	- Student usage of collections offered by library not tied to classwork - Students explore/familiarize themselves with library website to explore less visited collection and resources	- Increased number of students using a larger breadth of library materials - Increased traffic on library website exploring less visited collection pages	A semester after the program ends there will be a 7% increase in the circulation for books placed in the leisure section of the library and other collections not usually tied to academic classes One month after the program, there will be a 5% increase in the amount of tracked clicks on the library leisure collections page and other less visited	The number and percentage of increases of check outs for books placed in the leisure section and other less visited collections at the end of the semester in comparison to the semester before The number and percentage of increase of tracked clicks on the leisure reads collection

				collection pages	page and other less visited collection pages on the library website one month after the event in compariso n to the month before. .
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2. Increased foot traffic and usage of library by low usage patrons	1. Leisure reading collection (existing resource) 2. Library lounge spaces and seating (existing resource) 3. Use of other resources located within library	Student use of leisure reading collection, other library collection, and library spaces	Increased numbers of students coming to the library and using library resources and spaces	One semester after the program, there will be a 5% increase in the total number of students swiping into the Charles Library One semester after the program there will be a 3% increase in the study room reservations	An increase in the percentage of the student body at Temple entering Charles Library at the end of the semester in comparison to the semester before. An increase in the amount of room reservation requests the library receives from students at the end of the semester in comparison to the semester before
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3. Increased circulation of leisure reading materials (fiction & nonfiction)	1. Leisure reading collection (existing resource) 2. Book displays (existing resource, 1 staff, 2 hours every month; funding = staffing budget)	Students perusing leisure book section and checking out leisure books	Increased number of books checked out from the leisure reading section of the library	5% increase in the number of books checked out from the leisure section each month	The number and percentage of increased number of check outs from the leisure library section each month after the program in comparison to the statistics from before the program
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Budget

Line Item	Estimated Cost
Decor	150.00
Supplies for craft activity	250.00
Marketing	200.00
Food and drink	400.00
Staffing (cleaning services)	150.00
Prizes/Giveaways	100.00
Total	1250.00

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Appendices

Figure 1: Map of Floor 1 of Charles Library

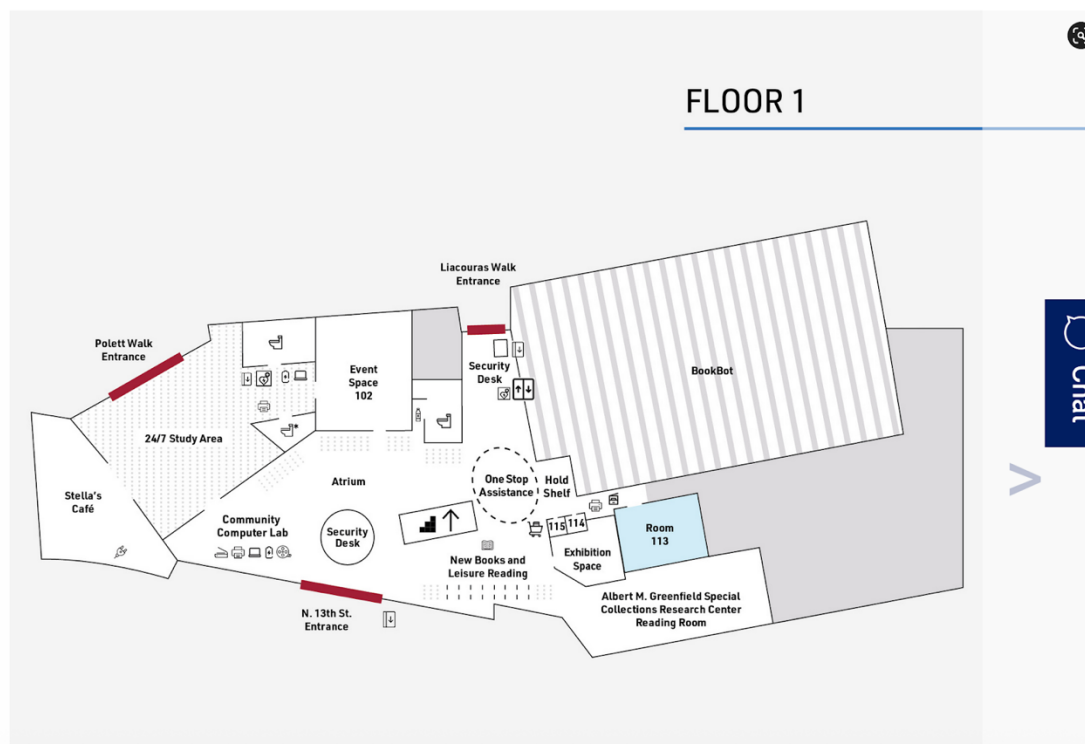


Figure 2: Printing data from Fall 2018-Fall 2024

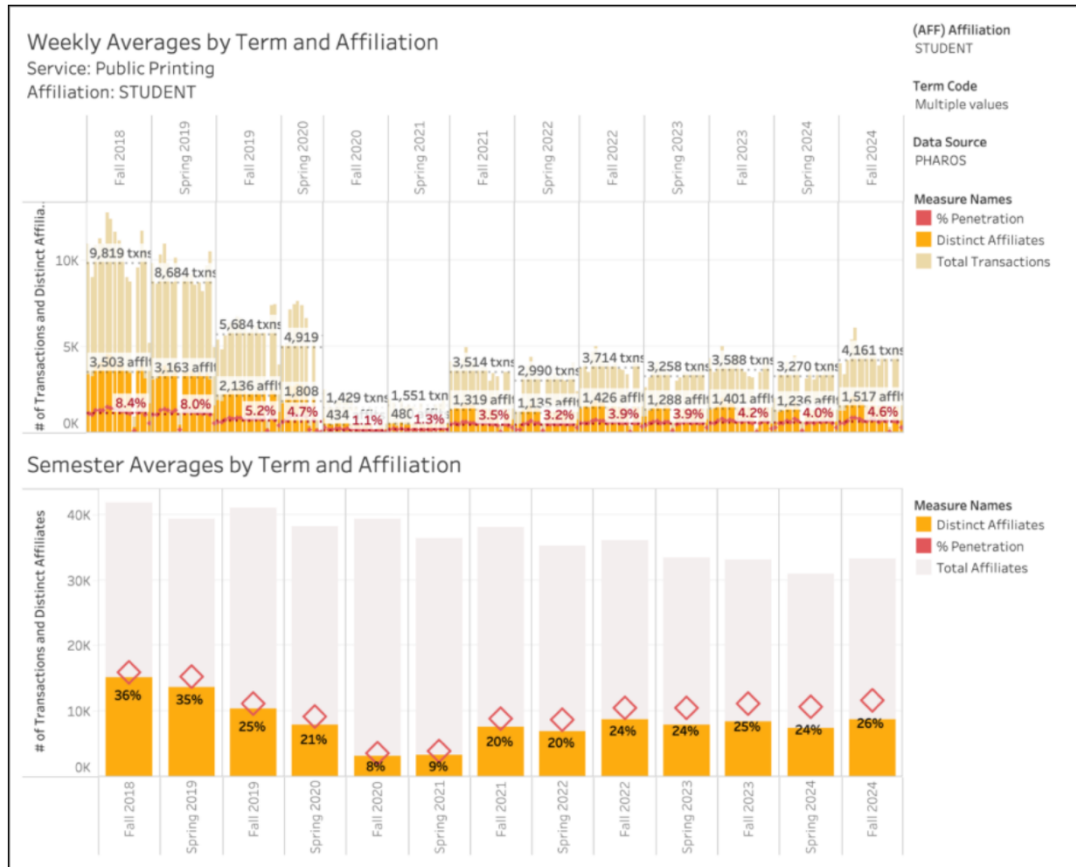


Figure 3: Charles Library student swipe data by school affiliation from Fall 2024.

